

SERIES

Yemen

All the pieces in the series in a single document, in reading order. Updated 5 November 2026.

The war in Yemen, from its origins to today, in six pieces: who the Houthis are, how the war with Saudi Arabia came back and what the parties want, then two in-depth pieces on civilians: the detained UN staff and the children recruited to fight. The fifth piece covers 2026, the year the war returned in full, and explains why no one can say how many people it has killed. At the end comes the country profile, with the peoples, the history and the actors, for readers who want to go deeper.

CONTENTS

1. Houthis (Ansar Allah): who they are, where they come from, what they want
2. Airport for airport: how the war between the Houthis and Saudi Arabia came back, and what each side wants
3. Yemen: 73 UN staff still arbitrarily detained by the Houthis, as Hodeidah bleeds again
4. Yemen: war intensifies again and fuels child recruitment, as the UN warns of famine risk
5. Yemen, the war is back in full: four thousand dead in a month and a number no one can give
6. Yemen: its peoples, its history, who is fighting and why

Houthis (Ansar Allah): who they are, where they come from, what they want

When an article on this site talks about "the Houthis", it assumes the reader knows who they are. Often that is not the case: in the news they appear as "pro-Iranian rebels" or as "terrorists", two labels that say little about their history or about what they are asking for. This entry gathers the essential facts. It can be updated: every change is recorded at the bottom, with date and source.

WHO THEY ARE

The Houthis are a political, religious and armed movement from northern Yemen. The official name is Ansar Allah, "the supporters of God". "Houthi" comes from the family that founded it and leads it. Since 2014 they have controlled the capital Sanaa and much of the country's north-west, including the port of Hodeidah on the Red Sea, and they govern there as a de facto authority. The UN-recognised government is based in Aden, in the south.

WHERE THEY COME FROM

The Houthis emerged from within Zaydism, a branch of Shia Islam present in Yemen since the ninth century and different from the Shiism practised in Iran. States led by Zaydi imams ruled northern Yemen, in various forms, until 1962, when the republican revolution overthrew the last imam (Sana'a Center).

In the early 1990s, in Saada province, a group of clerics launched a Zaydi revival movement made up of lectures, summer camps and recorded sermons. Its leading figure was Hussein Badreddin al-Houthi. The movement presented itself as the voice of an oppressed minority and as a response to two developments: the decline of Zaydism's role after the revolution and the spread in the north of Wahhabi Salafism coming from Saudi Arabia (Sana'a Center). In 2004 the government of President Ali Abdullah Saleh tried to arrest Hussein al-Houthi; this started the first of six wars in Saada province, which lasted until 2010. Hussein was killed in the first months of fighting, in 2004. Since then the movement has been led by his brother, Abdul-Malik al-Houthi.

In 2011 the Houthis took part in the uprising against Saleh under the name Ansar Allah. On 21 September 2014, allied with Saleh himself, they entered Sanaa. On 26 March 2015 a coalition led by Saudi Arabia intervened against them (Sana'a Center). In December 2017 they killed Saleh, who was switching sides.

WHAT THEY BELIEVE

Their motto, the *sarkha* ("the scream"), was according to the Houthis first uttered by Hussein al-Houthi in 2002: "God is great, death to America, death to Israel, a curse on the Jews, victory to Islam". It echoes the mottos of the Iranian revolution and of Hezbollah (Sana'a Center). It must be quoted in full because it contains an invective explicitly aimed at Jews, not only at the United States and Israel.

At the heart of their political doctrine is *wilayah*: the divine right to lead the community in politics and religion, reserved for the descendants of the al-Houthi family. In the areas they control, Abdul-Malik al-Houthi is the supreme authority over the economic, judicial and security apparatus. According to the Sana'a Center, only a minority of Yemenis accept this conception of power (Sana'a Center).

THE RELATIONSHIP WITH IRAN

The Houthis are part of the "axis of resistance", the network of Tehran's allies that includes Hezbollah. As early as 2021 a UN panel of experts reported growing evidence of shipments of weapons and components to the Houthis by individuals or entities in Iran, in violation of Security Council resolutions (Fox News, quoting the report). The report speaks of actors in Iran, not directly of the Iranian government.

Alliance, however, does not mean dependence. The Houthis have their own social base, history and doctrine, born in Yemen decades before Iranian support. In 2026 they presented the resumption of the war with Saudi Arabia as a continuation of the Yemeni war, not as a front of the Iran war (AP, via Al-Ahram).

WHAT THEY DEMAND

Their demands have changed over time. During the 2022 truce and the talks with Riyadh they asked above all for the payment of public-sector salaries in the areas they control, the opening of the ports and of Sanaa airport, and oil and gas revenues (AFP, via Naharnet). Much of this went into the commitments announced by the UN envoy at the end of 2023 for a peace "roadmap", which then stalled (UN News). According to the International Crisis Group, in 2026 the discourse shifted to Yemen's sovereignty over airspace, ports and territorial waters (AP, via Al-Ahram). On 19 August 2026 they told Saudi Arabia that the only way out was to lift the blockade, implement the measures already agreed, pay salaries, withdraw foreign forces and leave natural resources to Yemenis (Shafaq News).

DOCUMENTED VIOLATIONS

The Houthis are a party to a conflict in which all actors have violated international law, and this site documents it for all of them. As far as the Houthis are concerned, the documented violations include:

- the arbitrary detention of dozens of United Nations staff since 2024 (we covered it here);
- the recruitment of children as fighters (here);
- the siege of the city of Taiz, which began in 2016 (AFP, via Naharnet);
- since 2023, attacks on commercial ships in the Red Sea, which the Houthis present as solidarity with Gaza;
- in 2026, missile and drone attacks on Saudi civilian airports.

In the same conflict the Houthis and the population of the areas they control are also targets of violations by others, from the Saudi coalition's air strikes to the American ones of 2025. We cover them in the dedicated pieces.

WHAT THEY ARE CALLED

No label is neutral. "Rebels" stresses that they rose up against a recognised government; "de facto authority" describes the real control they exercise over millions of people; "terrorists" echoes the designations of some governments. This site normally uses "Houthis" and, when speaking of their administration, "Houthi de facto authorities".

US designations have changed with administrations. In January 2021 the first Trump administration designated them a foreign terrorist organisation; a month later the Biden administration revoked the designation, fearing it would hinder humanitarian aid. In February 2024 the same Biden administration designated them again, but in a narrower category, after the attacks in the Red Sea (Baker McKenzie). On 4 March 2025 the State Department designated them a foreign terrorist organisation again (State Department, via GlobalSecurity).

For the UN Security Council, resolution 2216 of 2015 demands that the Houthis withdraw from the areas they seized and imposes an arms embargo on them (UN).

CHANGE LOG

- 11 October 2026: first version.

Sources: Sana'a Center · Fox News, quoting the report · AP, via Al-Ahram · AFP, via Naharnet · UN News · Shafaq News · Baker McKenzie · State Department, via GlobalSecurity · UN

Airport for airport: how the war between the Houthis and Saudi Arabia came back, and what each side wants

IN BRIEF

- On the evening of 10 October an attack on King Khalid airport in Riyadh killed 12 people, including 8 foreigners, and injured 309, according to the Saudi civil aviation authority. It is the deadliest in an escalation that began in July.
- The trigger: on 13 July a strike hit the runway of Sanaa airport to stop an Iranian plane carrying a Houthi delegation from landing. Yemen's government, allied with Riyadh, claimed it; the Houthis blame Saudi Arabia. Since then the two sides have been hitting each other's airports.
- But the war was not born in July: it has been open since 2014, with Saudi intervention since 2015, frozen by a truce in 2022 and never closed by a peace agreement.
- The Houthis demand an end to the air and sea blockade, public-sector salaries, the withdrawal of foreign forces and control of the country's resources. Saudi Arabia wants to defend its territory and restore the recognised government. Washington has so far refused to intervene.
- It concerns people far away too: with Hormuz down to a fraction of its traffic, Gulf oil increasingly leaves through the Red Sea, and the Houthis are striking precisely those ports.

On the evening of Saturday 10 October, at King Khalid airport in Riyadh, Terminal 3 was evacuated amid ambulances and helicopters. The next day the Saudi civil aviation authority gave the figures: 12 dead, four Saudis and eight foreigners including an American, and 309 injured, some seriously (ANSA). The news bulletins condemned the attack, as they should. Almost no one explained why a Yemeni armed movement fires missiles at the Saudi capital, or what it asks for in order to stop. We try to do that.

THE FACTS

It is the third attack on Saudi airports in a week. On 6 and 7 October strikes on Riyadh and Abha had killed a Sudanese man, a Moroccan woman and an Algerian woman and injured 36 people; on 8 October three Saudis died in Riyadh, including a Saudia airline captain (Khaleej Times). The Houthis' military spokesman, Yahya Saree, claimed those attacks and warned airlines that

every aircraft in Saudi airspace is a target, except those bound for Mecca and Medina (Al Jazeera).

For 10 October the Houthis claimed strikes on "sensitive sites" in Riyadh and on Aramco facilities in Yanbu, without naming the airport, as a response to Saudi attempts to hit Sanaa (AFP, via TNND). The type of missile and Terminal 3 as the point of impact come from anonymous sources quoted by AFP and the Wall Street Journal (ANSA): they are not officially confirmed.

HOW WE GOT HERE

The Houthis (who they are, in our Glossary) are an armed movement born in the 1990s in northern Yemen. Since 2014 they have controlled the capital, and since then the war has never ended (Council on Foreign Relations).

Date	Event
2004-2010	Six wars between the Houthis and the government of President Ali Abdullah Saleh.
September 2014	The Houthis take Sanaa.
March 2015	A coalition led by Saudi Arabia intervenes on behalf of the recognised government. In April UN Security Council resolution 2216 demands that the Houthis withdraw and imposes an arms embargo on them (UN).
End of 2021	According to the UN Development Programme, the war has caused 377,000 deaths, 60% from hunger and disease (Al Jazeera).
April 2022	UN-brokered truce. It expires in October but holds in practice: the Houthis stop striking Saudi Arabia (DAWN).
December 2023	The UN envoy announces the parties' commitments to a "roadmap": ceasefire, public-sector salaries, oil exports, reopening of roads, ports and the airport (UN News). The plan stalls with the Houthi attacks on ships in the Red Sea, launched over the war in Gaza. US strikes follow in 2025 (here).

The trigger of 13 July. That day a strike hits the runway of Sanaa airport and prevents an Iranian plane carrying a senior Houthi delegation from landing; after Omani mediation the plane lands in Hodeidah (AP, via Al-Ahram). Who struck is disputed. AP speaks of a Saudi strike and the Houthis blame Riyadh; the defence ministry of Yemen's government, in Aden, says instead that its own forces did it. Saudi Arabia has not commented (Al-Monitor). The government says the

flight was carrying personnel and dual-use equipment: an accusation not independently verified, to which Tehran has not replied (The National). From there the spiral: missiles on Abha airport, the naval blockade declared by the Houthis on 20 July (here), offensives towards Taiz and Bab el-Mandeb, then the airports. By early October more than 200,000 people had been displaced in this new phase, according to the International Organization for Migration (Al Jazeera).

WHY IT CONCERNS EVERYONE: TWO STRAITS

Before the war with Iran, which began on 28 February, about 125 large commercial vessels passed through Hormuz every day; on Tuesday 6 October, according to Kpler data, there were seven commercial vessels, the lowest number since July (Reuters, via AAP; here our piece on the strait). Oil has found other outlets: 6.7 million barrels a day leave from the Gulf of Oman coast and the Red Sea, more than double the pre-war level (Reuters, via AAP). For Saudi Arabia the outlet is Yanbu, on the Red Sea. According to Kpler data, between March and July 2026 an average of 3.8 million barrels a day left Yanbu, about five times the earlier level; in August, as Houthi attacks resumed, 1.5 million (AFP, via Al-Ahram). In September an attack halted exports from Yanbu for a week. General traffic in the Red Sea, on the other hand, is holding up: 280 ships a week at Bab el-Mandeb in the month to 27 September, against 316 in June (Lloyd's List Intelligence). The Houthis deny wanting to close the strait; according to the Institute for the Study of War their target is Saudi Arabia's ability to export oil (AFP, via Al-Ahram).

The risk, then, is not a total blockade today. It is that both outlets for Gulf oil remain under threat at the same time.

WHAT THE PARTIES WANT

We report the declared positions, not attributed motives.

Party	What it says it wants
Houthis	On 19 August they said the only way out for Riyadh is to lift the blockade, implement the measures already agreed to end the conflict, pay salaries, withdraw foreign forces and leave natural resources to Yemenis (Shafaq News). The statement does not say which measures: the only agreed measures made public are those of the 2023 UN roadmap. According to the International Crisis Group, they have moved from asking for confidence-building measures, such as salaries, to presenting the conflict as a question of sovereignty over airspace, ports and waters (AP, via Al-Ahram).
Saudi Arabia and the coalition	To defend Saudi territory and "Yemen's sovereignty", meaning that of the recognised government. Riyadh rejects the accusation of a siege and says it let more than 300 ships through to Houthi ports in the first half of 2026 (here). In September Mohammed bin Salman asked Trump, in two phone calls in a single day, to strike the Houthis (Axios).
Yemen's recognised government	The restoration of its authority over the country, on the basis of resolution 2216. It is divided: between December 2025 and January 2026 southern separatists attempted a secession that Riyadh attributes to support from the Emirates (here).
Iran	An ally of the Houthis. We found no official statements from Tehran on the attacks on the airports. The Houthis present the escalation as a Yemeni war, not as a front of the Iran war (AP, via Al-Ahram).
United States	No intervention so far: Trump offered only intelligence and targeting data, fearing, according to a former Pentagon official, a Houthi reaction at Bab el-Mandeb and a rise in oil prices (Axios). After 10 October he called the attack "not acceptable": "We'll make a decision" (ANSA).
Pakistan	Islamabad's foreign ministry spokesman said Pakistani troops will not cross the border to attack the Houthis but will act in defence of the territory (Al Jazeera).

LEGAL READING AND SYMMETRY TEST

Airports are civilian objects, in Riyadh as in Sanaa. International humanitarian law requires states and armed groups always to distinguish between military objectives and civilian objects (ICRC, rule 7). A civilian airport loses protection only if it is used for military purposes, and even then an attack must not cause civilian harm that is excessive in relation to the expected advantage. A missile on a terminal, with 12 dead and 309 injured, is hard to justify by this standard; the same goes for the threat against any civilian aircraft in Saudi skies. But the rule

also applies to the runway in Sanaa. Yemen's government says the flight was carrying military equipment: if this were proven, the embargo in resolution 2216 would give the action a basis. But there is no public evidence, and an unproven accusation does not turn a civilian airport into a target.

The blockade. The one declared by the Houthis and the one the Houthis attribute to Riyadh follow the same rules: a blockade is unlawful if it starves civilians or if the harm to civilians is excessive in relation to the military advantage. For both, independent verification is lacking.

The condemnations. The October attacks were condemned by the United Nations and by many governments (Aviation Week), including Qatar, Oman, Egypt (Al Jazeera) and the Emirates (Khaleej Times); after 10 October the UN envoy Hans Grundberg spoke of a grave escalation (ANSA). Saudi Arabia and Yemen's government asked the Security Council to act (Al Jazeera). The strike on the Sanaa runway was not explicitly condemned by anyone at the Security Council on 14 July: the UN warned that unilateral measures do not bring peace closer, the United States blamed Iran (The National). And the same yardstick applies to the whole war: more than 25,000 coalition air strikes since 2015, with nearly 19,000 civilians killed according to the Council on Foreign Relations; the Houthi siege of the city of Taiz, which began in 2016 (AFP, via Naharnet).

EDITORIAL JUDGEMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Condemning a missile on an airport is a duty, and we reaffirm it. But a condemnation without context makes the war look like an outburst of madness. This war has a long history and precise demands, many of which were already written into the UN roadmap of 2023: salaries, ports, the airport, oil. The parties had said yes to it, and in August the Houthis asked for the measures already agreed to be implemented. Then Gaza, then the war with Iran, then a runway hit to stop a flight.

There is also a lesson about selective memory. Hitting the runway in Sanaa and hitting the terminal in Riyadh are acts of the same kind, even if with very different consequences: using a civilian airport to punish the adversary. Al Jazeera's correspondent in Sanaa summed up the logic declared by the Houthis like this: "airport for airport". Whoever condemns one and stays silent about the other is not defending the law: they are choosing a side.

One question remains about Washington. Trump said no to Riyadh for months, out of fear of a new front and of the price of oil, according to the sources. The midterm elections in November may be another reason, but no source we have read documents it: we flag it only as a

hypothesis. After 10 October that caution could end. If the United States enters this war, it is worth remembering that a document already exists to which both sides had said yes.

WHAT TO WATCH

- Trump's decision on an intervention alongside Saudi Arabia.
- An explicit Houthi claim for 10 October and the official Saudi report on Terminal 3.
- Exports from Yanbu and traffic at Bab el-Mandeb.
- The fighting around Taiz and Mokha and the number of displaced people.
- The initiatives of the UN envoy and of Oman to reopen negotiations.

Sources: ANSA · Khaleej Times · Al Jazeera · AFP, via TNND · Council on Foreign Relations · UN · Al Jazeera · DAWN · UN News · AP, via Al-Ahram · Al-Monitor · The National · Reuters, via AAP · AFP, via Al-Ahram · Lloyd's List Intelligence · Shafaq News · Axios · Al Jazeera · ICRC, rule 7 · Aviation Week · Khaleej Times · AFP, via Naharnet

Yemen: 73 UN staff still arbitrarily detained by the Houthis, as Hodeidah bleeds again

> *«These actions violate international law, cause deep suffering to families.» — António Guterres, UN Secretary-General, 12 June 2026*

THE FACTS

On 5 July 2026, Houthi fighters attacked Yemeni government force positions in the Hodeidah region (Hays area), on the Red Sea coast, using mortars, drones and sniper fire: 16 soldiers killed and 22 wounded, according to medical and military sources cited by Al Jazeera — the fiercest clashes in years along a frontline frozen since 2022. The same day, a commercial vessel was attacked off Hodeidah, with no claim of responsibility. In parallel, and over a longer period: as of 12 June 2026, 73 United Nations staff — all Yemeni nationals — remained arbitrarily detained by the Houthi de facto authorities, as part of an arrest campaign that began in May 2024 and has never concluded; one World Food Programme worker died in Houthi custody on 11 February 2025. On 29 January 2026 the WFP announced it was terminating the contracts of all 365 of its staff in Houthi-controlled northern Yemen — where 70% of the country's humanitarian need is concentrated — explicitly citing the operating environment made unsafe by arbitrary detentions. On 27 January 2026 the UN Security Council voted a final extension, to 31 March, of the mission supporting the Hodeidah Agreement (UNMHA), which was then shut down: the United States pushed for its closure, arguing Houthi obstruction had made it ineffective; China and Russia voted to keep it. In the background, 21.6 million people remain in need of assistance (11 million children), 4.5 million are displaced, and the 2026 UN humanitarian appeal of $2.16 billion was only 29% funded in 2025.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

The arbitrary detention of UN staff — often without a warrant, with cases of enforced disappearance lasting months and one death in custody never clarified — violates Article 9 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (no one shall be subjected to arbitrary arrest or detention), to which Yemen has been a state party since 1987, as well as the immunities recognised for UN personnel acting in their official capacity. The systematic obstruction of humanitarian access — which already forced the WFP to suspend operations in Saada governorate — falls instead within the scope of the Geneva Conventions and their Additional

Protocol II, which prohibit impeding humanitarian relief to civilians in non-international armed conflicts. The two violations are distinct but reinforce one another: those who should guarantee access to aid are detained, and in doing so the very crisis that access should relieve is worsened.

IMPLICATIONS — THE SYMMETRY TEST

The principle — humanitarian personnel are not arbitrarily detained, relief access is not obstructed — applies to the Houthis exactly as it would to any other actor this site has already covered. But Yemen has no single culprit, which is what makes it a textbook case for symmetry: the Saudi-led coalition has conducted more than 25,000 air strikes since 2015 and caused nearly 19,000 civilian casualties according to the Council on Foreign Relations; the United Arab Emirates is accused by Riyadh of having armed the Southern Transitional Council's secessionist bid between December 2025 and January 2026, later repelled by pro-Saudi forces; the United States and the United Kingdom have struck Houthi targets directly since 2024. Applying the criterion only to the Houthis because they are the most visible actor at this moment — while staying silent on the coalition, the Emirates, and the Anglo-American strikes — would not pass the test.

APPENDIX: THE "ROUGH RIDER" CAMPAIGN AND THE SA'ADA STRIKE (MARCH-APRIL 2025)

An earlier episode, documented but not yet covered on this site, deserves reconstruction here because it sheds direct light on the symmetry principle applied above. Between March 15 and May 6, 2025, the United States conducted a campaign of air and naval strikes against Yemen, codenamed "Operation Rough Rider," in response to Houthi attacks on commercial shipping in the Red Sea: according to estimates by the independent organization Airwars, the US strikes killed at least 224 civilians.

On April 28, 2025, a US air strike hit a migrant detention centre in Sa'ada, north-western Yemen, killing and injuring dozens of African migrants held there by Houthi authorities. An Amnesty International investigation concluded that the strike constitutes an indiscriminate attack, to be investigated as a possible war crime. Asked by Amnesty, US Central Command (CENTCOM) said it was "assessing all reports of civilian harm" from that period; by the end of 2025 the results of that assessment had not been made public.

In the same timeframe, the Houthis resumed missile and drone attacks on Israel — a missile injured 4 people near the main terminal of Ben Gurion airport (May 4, 2025), a drone injured over 20 people near a hotel in Eilat (September 24, 2025) — alongside attacks on commercial

shipping in the Red Sea, sinking two vessels (Greek-owned, Liberian-flagged) and killing at least three crew members.

Sources (appendix): Amnesty International

Sources: Human Rights Watch · UN News · UN Secretary-General statement · Al Jazeera · Security Council Report · Congressional Research Service · CFR Global Conflict Tracker · Cairo Institute for Human Rights Studies · ICCPR official text (OHCHR)

Yemen: war intensifies again and fuels child recruitment, as the UN warns of famine risk

> *«This reflects a systematic policy of child recruitment.» — Ali Hazazi, Human Rights Office of the Presidency, Aden*

THE FACTS

Over the past week, more than 100 fighters from both sides have been killed in clashes between Houthi forces and government/pro-Saudi forces along the western Taiz and southern Hodeidah fronts (Kadha front) — the most intense escalation in years along the same frontline already reported on this site in July 2026. Over the same period, Hazazi documented 62 new child-recruitment cases in the second quarter of 2026 in Houthi-controlled provinces, calling them "only a fraction" of the real phenomenon, since most cases go unreported. SAM Organization for Rights and Liberties, which monitors human rights violations in the country, recorded 11,310 children recruited or used across 19 governorates between 2014 and 2023, including 6,269 aged 8 to 11.

Individual cases collected by Al Jazeera show explicit financial compensation for enlistment: around 50,000 Yemeni rials (210 dollars) as a one-off payment, or a monthly wage of around 45,000 rials (80 dollars) — slightly above the local average wage, in a country where more than four in five rural children live in poverty. Pro-government forces have captured numerous Houthi child soldiers, including on the al-Dhale front; the sources consulted for this cycle show no comparable cases of recruitment on the government side (see the symmetry test below).

In the background, UN humanitarian chief Tom Fletcher told the Security Council in mid-August 2026 that 6 million people face "emergency" levels of deprivation bordering on famine. A joint report by ACAPS/FAO/UNICEF/World Bank/WFP/WHO from early 2026 ranks Yemen fourth worldwide for food insecurity, with 18.3 million people projected to be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or worse. The UN Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan (HNRP) 2026, published by OCHA on 18 March 2026, estimates 22.3 million people in need of assistance and protection in the country, including 5.2 million internally displaced people. Yemen also appears on the International Rescue Committee's 2026 Emergency Watchlist, published in December 2025 — that is, before any of this week's news.

On 20 July 2026 the Houthis declared a naval blockade against Saudi Arabia, calling it an "eye for an eye" response to what they describe as a Saudi land, sea and air siege lasting around 12 years

— a declaration that came after a Saudi strike on Sanaa airport, amid renewed regional tensions over Iran's role. Saudi Arabia rejected the siege accusation the following day, saying more than 300 ships carrying food, goods, fuel and construction materials had passed through the ports of Hodeidah, Salif and Ras Isa in the first half of 2026, and announced measures to protect maritime traffic in the Bab al-Mandab strait. Neither side has so far provided independent verification of how the Houthi-declared blockade is actually being enforced.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

Recruiting and using children under 15 in combat is a war crime under the Rome Statute, art. 8(2)(b)(xxvi) and (e)(vii); the Optional Protocol to the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, to which Yemen is a state party, extends the recruitment ban up to age 18. It should be noted that some of the documented cases involve 17-year-olds: an age bracket where international law still bans use in combat, but not under the same absolute threshold set for under-15s — a legal distinction that should not be flattened. Both the Yemeni government (with a UN action plan signed in 2014) and the Houthis (with a similar agreement in 2022) had committed to ending the practice; the evidence gathered in this cycle shows the Houthi commitment remains largely unmet.

IMPLICATIONS — THE SYMMETRY TEST

The principle — no recruitment of children, by any actor — would apply equally to Houthi forces as to government or pro-Saudi forces: this is not a judgment reserved for one side. But applying it honestly here also means saying what this cycle's sources do not show: unlike the case already covered on this site in July (where the Saudi coalition, the UAE and the US/UK shared comparable, documented responsibility), the sources available for 2026 child recruitment are concentrated almost entirely on the Houthi side — pro-government forces appear to be capturing children recruited by the Houthis, not recruiting them in turn in this cycle. A known precedent (recruitment also by the Yemeni army during the 2011 uprising against Saleh) shows the phenomenon has never been exclusive to one actor in the past — but applying that to the present without a comparable 2026 source would be a manufactured symmetry, not a found one. The asymmetry is therefore stated rather than papered over. On humanitarian access, by contrast, the picture remains two-sided, as in the July case already published on this site: the Houthis accuse Saudi Arabia of a years-long siege, Riyadh denies it and claims hundreds of ships transited Houthi ports in the same period — neither version has been independently verified, and both should be reported as competing claims, not as an established fact favouring either side.

JUDGMENT

Stated as such, separate from the facts above: poverty does not justify child recruitment — it remains a crime regardless of who commits it or the economic conditions of those who consent to it — but it explains why the "choice" keeps presenting itself as one. A payment of 80 dollars a month, in a country where four in five rural children live in poverty, is not a neutral incentive: it is the difference between a meal and no meal for a family. Poverty does not help families choose otherwise when the immediate alternative is hunger — it does not absolve those who recruit, but it narrows the real space of choice for those who consent.

Sources: Al Jazeera — child recruitment and the Taiz/Hodeidah offensive · Al Jazeera — Tom Fletcher's remarks to the Security Council · OCHA/ReliefWeb — Yemen Humanitarian Response Plan 2026 (18/3/2026) · SAM Organization for Rights and Liberties · International Crisis Group — Ahmed Nagi, Senior Analyst Yemen · IRC — Emergency Watchlist 2026 · ACAPS/FAO/UNICEF/World Bank/WFP/WHO — Yemen Joint Monitoring Report · CFR Global Conflict Tracker · Al-Ahram (AP) — Houthi naval blockade declaration, 20/7/2026 · Arab News — Saudi response, 21/7/2026

Verification note: the naval blockade is reported as competing claims (announced by the Houthis on 20/7/2026, rejected by Riyadh on 21/7/2026); no independent verification of its actual enforcement is available. For the number of people in need of assistance we use the most recent OCHA figure (22.3 million, March 2026), which supersedes the 21.6 million cited in the July piece.

5/6 · ANALYSIS · 4 NOVEMBER 2026

Yemen, the war is back in full: four thousand dead in a month and a number no one can give

IN BRIEF

- Since September Yemen has been at war again on every front. On 9 October the UN envoy Hans Grundberg told the Security Council that the country has "slid back into full-scale war".
- ACLED, the monitor we use for our Map, counts 8,804 deaths in 2026 as of 23 October: four weeks earlier there were 4,689, and 2,940 in the whole of 2025. The WHO counts at least 1,574 since August, but receives no data from Houthi-held areas. The numbers do not contradict each other: they count different things, in different places.
- Taiz, the most populous governorate, is again besieged by the Houthis. For Human Rights Watch the siege may amount to a war crime: starving civilians as a method of warfare.
- On the other side, Saudi-led coalition strikes on Sanaa and the north also hit factories and telephone networks. There, no one independently verifies who dies.
- The Houthis are neither Iran's puppet nor an independent movement: they depend on Tehran for their most advanced weapons, but on choices that touch their survival they decide for themselves. In 2026 the bond is the closest ever documented, and the two agendas coincide.
- No court and no international commission is investigating the crimes of this war today.

Until the summer, Yemen was a mid-sized bubble on our Map: fewer deaths than Sudan, far fewer than Ukraine. Then, when we updated the ACLED data at the end of October, the bubble almost doubled in four weeks. A jump like that can mean one of two things: either the war has changed, or the way it is counted has changed. We went to look. The war has changed. But the way it is counted explains why so little is said about it outside Yemen.

THE FACTS

The coast and the strait (September). On 3 September the Houthis launched an offensive in Taiz governorate, to cut the road between the city and the coast. On 10 September they took Mokha,

the historic port on the Red Sea about eighty kilometres from the Bab el-Mandeb (AFP, via Al-Monitor). In the following days they occupied the rest of the western coast and the Hanish islands (Long War Journal). For the first time they control a stretch of coast directly overlooking the strait. The strait matters more than usual today: with Hormuz almost closed by the war between the United States, Israel and Iran, in June more than 7 million barrels of oil and products a day passed through the Bab el-Mandeb (same source, on shipping data).

Taiz cut off (October). On 4 October the Houthis took al-Turbah and with it the last main road between the city of Taiz and Aden (Al Jazeera). Taiz had been under siege since 2015, but one route had stayed open. On 23 October the UN humanitarian agency (OCHA) counted twenty days of isolation. The World Food Programme says it cannot reach more than 600,000 people who depend on aid; the UN humanitarian coordinator, Laurent Bukera, said the city's water production has halved and the health system is "close to collapse" (Human Rights Watch, 29/10/2026).

The counter-offensive (October–November). On the same day, 4 October, the head of the Presidential Leadership Council, Rashad al-Alimi, announced an offensive to retake all Houthi territory, Sanaa included (AAP, via Illawarra Mercury). The Saudi-led coalition said it was taking part with a hundred fighter jets (Al Jazeera, 7/10/2026). In early November the hardest fighting was in al-Jawf, to the north-east, around Taiz and in northern Lahij, on the line between Taiz and Aden (Al Jazeera, 4/11/2026).

The deadliest attacks. On 19 October three Houthi ballistic missiles hit a security forces training camp in Shabwa, in the south: 73 dead, all recruits aged 18 to 20, and more than 200 wounded, according to the governor of the province (AP, via Korea Times). The Houthis say the camp was run by the Saudis (Reuters, via Express Tribune). Since the start of October the Houthis have struck Saudi airports and oil facilities almost daily; we wrote about it in "Airport for airport". The Houthis say Saudi strikes on their territory have numbered more than 2,700 (dpa, via Qatar Tribune); the figure cannot be verified.

Those who flee. Between 1 August and 12 October the International Organization for Migration counted 217,303 displaced people (IOM, via UNI), the highest number since the 2022 truce (The National); at the end of October the UN spoke of more than 250,000 (L'Orient-Le Jour). More than 3,800 have crossed the sea to Djibouti (UN, via Al Jazeera).

THE NUMBERS: WHY THEY DON'T ADD UP

There are three counts, and none of them is wrong.

Who counts	What they count	How many	Where they reach
ACLED	deaths from all political violence, fighters included, from news and local partners	8,804 in 2026 as of 23 October; more than 6,400 since the war resumed (ACLED, via dpa)	the whole country, with the most conservative figures available
WHO	dead and wounded recorded by health facilities	at least 1,574 dead and 6,939 wounded since August	only where hospitals report: not from Houthi-held areas
UN human rights office	civilian casualties verified one by one	at least 125 civilians killed or injured from August to 24 September (AFP, via Dhaka Tribune)	where it can verify, that is mostly in government areas

ACLED counts all deaths, soldiers included, and October's war is above all a war of soldiers: both sides announce hundreds of enemies killed every day. ACLED says it always uses the most conservative estimate available (ACCORD, methodology note); we do not know how much of its total comes from the parties' own figures. There is also a declared limit: since 2025 ACLED has expanded its coverage of Yemen with a local partner, and warns that data from before 2024 are not comparable with today's (ACLED). The comparison between 2025 and 2026, however, holds.

The point that matters for the reader is a different one. The WHO says it receives no figures from Houthi-held areas, where most Yemenis live. In August the UN counted 17 civilian casualties of Houthi attacks in government areas and 2 in Houthi areas (Volker Türk, High Commissioner for Human Rights, via TRT). This does not mean Saudi strikes do not kill: it means there is no one there to count them independently. Missing data is not data worth zero.

WHO'S WHO

Who	What they want	Who backs them
Houthis (Ansar Allah)	An end to the air and sea blockade, public salaries, the withdrawal of foreign forces, recognition of their power in the north.	Iran: weapons, components and advisers (see below). Who they are, in our Glossary.
Presidential Leadership Council (recognised government, in Aden)	To retake the whole country, Sanaa included.	Saudi Arabia: aircraft and money for salaries. UN resolution 2216 recognises it.
Saudi Arabia	To defend its territory and its oil routes, and keep the government standing.	The United States, politically.
Southern separatists	A southern state. The Southern Transitional Council, backed by the Emirates, dissolved in January after a defeat by pro-Saudi forces; its supporters say the decision was taken under pressure.	Partly the Emirates, until January.

HOUTHIS AND IRAN: ALLY OR PUPPET?

In the news the Houthis are almost always "the Iran-backed rebels", and Yemen's war becomes a front in the war against Iran. That is part of the truth. To see how large a part, it helps to separate three things: the weapons, the people, the decisions.

Weapons: a strong dependence. Since 2018 UN experts have found in Houthi missiles and drones features of Iranian weapons and components made in Iran, in breach of the embargo of resolution 2216 (AFP, via Arab News). Conflict Armament Research, a British centre that examines seized weapons, studied more than 800 missile and drone components intercepted in the Red Sea in 2024 and 2025: the assembly labels use the Iranian names of the missiles, not the Houthi ones, and for the centre external support remains decisive (Conflict Armament Research; Jerusalem Post). The same study, however, shows that only 5% of those components were produced in Iran: the rest bear the marks of companies from 15 other countries, China and Europe included. Iran, in other words, acts mainly as a supply network and a source of designs. The Houthis also assemble and experiment on their own (The National).

People: in 2026, the most direct role ever documented. According to two anonymous Iranian sources quoted by Reuters, the 13 July 2026 flight from Tehran, the one the Yemeni government tried to stop by bombing the runway at Sanaa, carried between 10 and 21 members of the Revolutionary Guards, including senior officers, and missile and drone components. The Houthis say only civilians were on board; Tehran says the flight was bringing home a delegation and patients (Reuters, via bdnews24). On the coastal offensive, five Yemeni government military sources told Reuters that the Revolutionary Guards directed it, and two Iranian sources that Tehran asked the Houthis to step up attacks on Saudi Arabia, promising money, weapons and officers (Reuters, via The New Arab). An AP investigation, based on ten officials and soldiers, describes Revolutionary Guards advisers in the field who helped plan operations and analyse intelligence: the most direct Iranian involvement since the war began in 2014 (AP, via Iran International). These are mostly anonymous sources, and many belong to the Yemeni government, that is to a party to the war: we report them as unverified. Tehran denies directing the Houthis and says they are an ally, "not a proxy".

Decisions: more autonomy than is often said. An Iranian official, in the same Reuters report, says the taking of Mokha was a Houthi decision, not Iran's, even if it suited Iran. In 2014, according to US officials and later President Obama himself, Iran advised the Houthis against taking Sanaa; they took it anyway (HuffPost, 2015). In March 2026, when the United States and Israel attacked Iran, Hezbollah and the Iraqi militias entered the war within the first weeks (Reuters, via ARY); the Houthis held back for weeks, and analysts at ACLED and the Arab Gulf States Institute read this as a calculation about their own survival, not as an order received (ACLED; AGSI). Other analysts think instead that Tehran was holding them in reserve (same source). And the Houthis' story, the six wars with Saleh, the rivalry with Saudi Salafism, the power over Sanaa, began before Iranian support became important.

How we see it. "Iran's puppet" is wrong; "independent movement" is wrong too. The Houthis are an ally that depends on Iran for its most advanced weapons and decides on its own when what is at stake is its survival or power in Yemen. In 2026 the bond is the closest ever documented, and the two agendas coincide: Iran, under attack, has an interest in leverage over the Bab el-Mandeb and Saudi oil; the Houthis have an interest in taking the coast and making Saudi Arabia pay for the blockade. Those who read this war only as a proxy war forget that it is Yemenis who fight it, and die in it, for Yemeni reasons. Those who read it only as a civil war forget where the missiles that hit Riyadh come from.

The same yardstick. The question applies to the other side too. The government in Aden depends on Saudi Arabia for salaries, 346.6 million dollars in February 2026 alone (Arab News), for aircraft and for its very composition: in January 2026 Riyadh broke up the Emirati-backed separatists by force and replaced their members on the Presidential Council (TRT World). If the

Houthis are "pro-Iranian", the government is, by the same measure, "pro-Saudi". Neither label is enough on its own.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

Taiz and hunger as a weapon. Besieging a city defended by soldiers is not prohibited in itself. Using the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare is prohibited, and so is blocking aid without military necessity. It is a rule of customary international law, which applies in civil wars too and to an armed group such as the Houthis; Yemen, moreover, has been a party since 1990 to the Second Additional Protocol to the Geneva Conventions, which sets it out in Article 14 (ICRC, International Review of the Red Cross). For Human Rights Watch the siege of Taiz "may amount" to that crime; intent can be inferred from the circumstances, and people do not have to die of hunger to prove it. The Houthis reply that it is government forces that are closing the roads; residents, civil society workers and UN officials say the opposite.

The Shabwa camp. Were the 73 recruits a military target? It depends on what they were. A soldier in training is a combatant; a police officer, under humanitarian law, is a civilian, unless he is part of the armed forces or takes part in the fighting. The governor says they were training for security in the province, not for the front; the Houthis say the camp was Saudi. No one has yet verified it. It is the first question an investigation should ask.

The Saudi airports. A civilian airport full of passengers is a civilian object. Warning the airlines, as the Houthis did, does not make striking it lawful: it only makes it predictable.

The strikes on the north. The same rules apply to the coalition. Every strike on a factory, an antenna or a neighbourhood of Sanaa must hit a military objective and not cause civilian harm that is excessive in relation to the expected advantage. Whether it has done so or not, today no one knows, for the reason given above: in the north there is no one to verify.

Who judges. No one, for now. Yemen signed the Statute of the International Criminal Court in 2000 but never ratified it (Parliamentarians for Global Action); nor have Saudi Arabia and Iran. The UN group of experts that investigated crimes by all parties was shut down in 2021 by a vote of the Human Rights Council (International Commission of Jurists). Meanwhile 72 UN staff remain detained by the Houthis (Grundberg to the Security Council, 9/10/2026).

SYMMETRY TEST

The yardstick. If a regular army closed the last road into a city of hundreds of thousands of people and halved its water, this site would speak of starvation as a method of warfare. We say it

here in the same words, for an armed group that the government would like the UN to declare "terrorist" (Al Jazeera, 20/10/2026) and that its supporters call resistance.

The numbers. The data verified by the UN lean one way: almost all the civilian casualties counted were caused by the Houthis. But they lean that way because the UN works mostly on one side. In the years of the air war, between 2015 and 2019, ACLED attributed about two thirds of directly killed civilians to air strikes (ACLED, 2019). Reading the asymmetry of the data as an asymmetry of conduct would be a mistake, in either direction.

The truce. 2022 had stopped the war; no one had ended it. The demands of the Houthis and of the government were already written into the UN "roadmap" of December 2023. Neither side today seems to think it can get more at the table than on the battlefield.

OUR VIEW

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Yemen's bubble on our Map has grown because the war really is back in full, not because of a counting error. But the most important figure is not the number: it is the hole in the number. In half the country the dead are counted from the communiqués of those who fight, and a war that is not counted is a war that is not judged.

Grundberg put it another way: gains on the battlefield cannot replace the negotiations that will in any case be needed to end the war. As long as no one investigates, each side can tell its own war as the only true one.

WHAT TO WATCH

- Whether the UN manages to open a humanitarian route to Taiz, as governor Nabil Shamsan asks.
- Grundberg's next briefing to the Security Council and any resolution on the Bab el-Mandeb.
- Whether anyone verifies the status of the Shabwa recruits and the coalition strikes in the north.
- ACLED's November data and the next UCDP release, to see whether the two sources converge.
- The fate of the 72 detained UN staff.

Sources: AFP, via Al-Monitor · Long War Journal · Al Jazeera · Human Rights Watch, 29/10/2026 · AAP, via Illawarra Mercury · Al Jazeera, 7/10/2026 · Al Jazeera, 4/11/2026 · AP, via Korea Times · Reuters, via Express Tribune · dpa, via Qatar Tribune · IOM, via UNI · The National · L'Orient-Le Jour · UN, via Al Jazeera · ACLED, via dpa · AFP, via Dhaka Tribune · ACCORD, methodology note · ACLED · Volker Türk, High Commissioner for Human Rights, via TRT · AFP, via Arab News · Conflict Armament Research · Jerusalem Post · The National · Reuters, via bdnews24 · Reuters, via The New Arab · AP, via Iran International · HuffPost, 2015 · Reuters, via ARY · ACLED · AGSI · Arab News · TRT World · ICRC, International Review of the Red Cross · Parliamentarians for Global Action · International Commission of Jurists · Grundberg to the Security Council, 9/10/2026 · Al Jazeera, 20/10/2026 · ACLED, 2019

Yemen: its peoples, its history, who is fighting and why

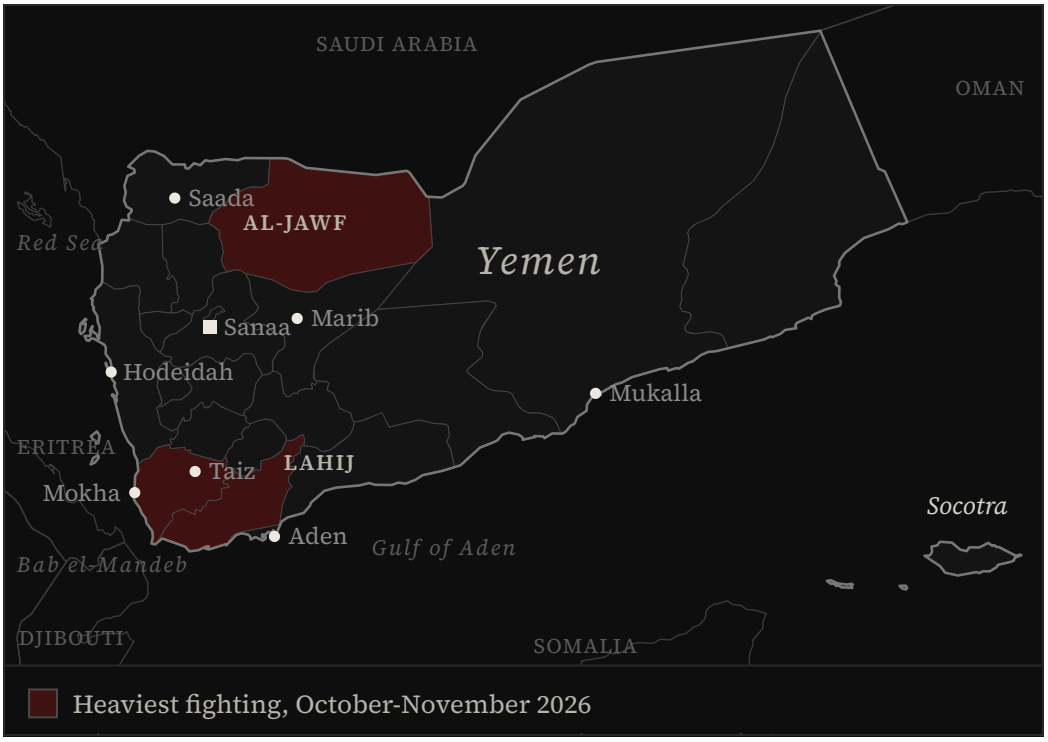
The news from Yemen talks about missiles fired at Saudi airports, ships hit in the Red Sea, a besieged city, but it rarely explains why the poorest country in the Arab world has been at war for more than ten years, who the parties are and why so many foreign states have got involved. This profile tries to give the background. It is kept up to date: every change is recorded at the bottom, with date and source.

IN BRIEF

- Yemen has about 33.7 million inhabitants, almost all Arab and Muslim. The difference that matters most is religious and geographical: a Sunni majority of the Shafi'i school, mainly in the centre and south, and a large Zaydi minority, a branch of Shia Islam, in the northern mountains.
- For a thousand years, until 1962, the north was ruled on and off by Zaydi imams. The south was a British colony around Aden for more than a century, then a Marxist state. The two Yemens united only in 1990, and by 1994 they had already fought a war.
- Since 2014 the Houthis, an armed Zaydi movement allied with Iran, have controlled the capital Sanaa and the north-west, where most Yemenis live. Since 2015 a coalition led by Saudi Arabia has fought for the recognised government, now based in Aden.
- The 2022 truce stopped the war without ending it. In 2026 the war returned on every front. No international court is investigating the crimes committed.

THE PEOPLES

Yemen occupies the south-western corner of the Arabian Peninsula. To the west it faces the Red Sea, to the south the Gulf of Aden; the Bab el-Mandeb strait, between Yemen and Djibouti, is one of the busiest waterways in the world. The country is made up of high, fertile mountains in the west, a hot coastal plain on the Red Sea (the Tihama) and deserts and plateaus in the east, up to Hadramawt and the border with Oman. Offshore, in the Indian Ocean, lies the island of Socotra. Yemen is divided into 21 governorates plus the capital.



In dark red, the provinces where, according to our analysis of 4 November 2026, the fighting is heaviest: al-Jawf, Taiz (with the Mokha coast, taken by the Houthis in September) and Lahij. We do not draw front lines or the areas held by each side, which change from week to week. The square marks the capital, Sanaa, held by the Houthis since 2014; the recognised government sits in Aden. Boundaries: Natural Earth (21 governorates and the capital).

The population. Freedom House estimates about 33.7 million inhabitants (Freedom House). The last census dates from 2004, when there were 19.7 million Yemenis (GlobalSecurity, on census data): since then every figure is an estimate.

A warning about the numbers. There are no official statistics on the religion or origin of Yemenis, and the estimates in circulation differ widely. We give them side by side, with the source, and say when they diverge.

- **Arabs, Sunnis of the Shafi'i school** — the majority: 65% according to the US government (US State Department, 2023, via ecoi.net), 55% of Muslims according to ACLED (same source). They live mainly in the cities of Taiz, Ibb and Aden, in the Tihama and in Hadramawt. The Shafi'i school is one of the four schools of Sunni Islamic law.
- **Arabs, Zaydis** — 35% according to the US government, 45% of Muslims according to ACLED (same source). Zaydism is a branch of Shia Islam present in Yemen since the 9th century, different from Iranian Shiism; Zaydis live mainly in the mountains north of Dhamar (Minority Rights Group). The Houthis present themselves as defenders of the Zaydis, but not all Zaydis are Houthis.

- **Ismailis** — about 15,000 people, concentrated in the Haraz area near Sanaa (same source). They are another Shia branch.
- **Muhamasheen** ("the marginalised") — from 500,000 to 3.5 million people, according to estimates cited by the UN and other studies (Sana'a Center); the highest figure would be about 10% of the population (Minority Rights Group). They are Black Yemenis, scornfully called *akhdam*, "servants". They belong to none of the big tribes and live on the margins, facing caste-like discrimination (same source).
- **Mahri, Soqotri and other South Arabian peoples** — they speak ancient languages distinct from Arabic, such as Mehri, Soqotri and Bathari (Minority Rights Group). They live in the far east, in al-Mahra province, and on the island of Socotra. We have not found a reliable estimate of their number.
- **Jews, Baha'is, Christians and Hindus** — together less than 1% (US State Department, 2022, via ecoi.net). The Jewish community, present for millennia, has almost disappeared: most emigrated to Israel after 1948, and in 2019 about fifty remained (US State Department, 2019, via ecoi.net).

The economy. The International Monetary Fund considers Yemen the poorest country in the world (Grundberg to the Security Council, DPPA). Its little oil and gas is almost all in the east, between Marib and Shabwa (AP, via Korea Times), far from where most of the population lives. Whoever controls those fields, the ports and the roads controls the state's revenue.

A SHORT HISTORY

Arabia Felix. In antiquity Yemen was the "Arabia Felix", happy Arabia, of Greek and Roman geographers: kingdoms grown rich on frankincense and myrrh and on irrigated farming. The best known is the kingdom of Saba, with its capital at Marib and its great dam; its remains, from the 1st millennium BC to the arrival of Islam around 630, have been a World Heritage site in danger since 2023, because they lie on a front line (UNESCO; Arab News).

A thousand years of imams (897-1962). In 897 a descendant of the Prophet, al-Hadi ila al-Haqq Yahya, arrived in Saada, in the north, and founded the Zaydi imamate: a state in which the imam is both religious and political leader (Encyclopedia.com). With many changes of fortune and long interruptions, the imams ruled the northern mountains for more than a thousand years. The Ottomans occupied the towns several times; in 1918, at the end of the Ottoman Empire, the north became independent under Imam Yahya (US Marine Corps, country profile).

British Aden (1839-1967). In 1839 the British occupied the port of Aden, a useful stop on the route to India; in 1904 a boundary line separated the Ottoman north from the south under British influence (Carnegie). This is where two Yemens were born.

Revolution and war in the north (1962-1970). On 26 September 1962 a group of officers overthrew the new imam, Muhammad al-Badr, and proclaimed the Yemen Arab Republic. The imam fled and rallied the tribes: a civil war began in which Nasser's Egypt sent troops for the republic and Saudi Arabia backed the royalists. In 1967 Egypt withdrew most of its soldiers for the Six-Day War; in 1970 the two sides were reconciled (Encyclopedia.com; MIT, CASCON project).

The independent, Marxist South (1967-1990). From 1963 a guerrilla war was fought against the British; on 30 November 1967 the South became independent. In 1969 the Marxists took power, founded the People's Democratic Republic of Yemen, the only Marxist state in the Arab world, and nationalised property (Carnegie; Orient XXI; PBS). In 1972 and 1979 North and South fought two short border wars, both ended by agreements that promised a unification that never came (UCDP).

Unification and the 1994 war. With the end of the Soviet Union the South lost its backer, and on 22 May 1990 the two states merged into the Republic of Yemen, with the North's leader, Ali Abdullah Saleh, as president (WorldAtlas). Many Southern leaders soon felt sidelined. In 1994 the South declared secession; on 7 July Saleh's troops took Aden and the war ended (US Marine Corps). Since then part of the South has experienced unity as an annexation.

Saleh and the Saada wars (1994-2011). Saleh ruled through a system of alliances between tribes, the army and parties, including the Islamist party Islah. From 2004 to 2010 he fought six wars in the north against the Houthi movement, born in the 1990s from a Zaydi religious revival (our Glossary).

Uprising and transition (2011-2014). In 2011, during the Arab Spring, millions of Yemenis took to the streets against Saleh. On 23 November 2011 Saleh signed a deal brokered by the Gulf states and handed power to his deputy, Abd Rabbu Mansour Hadi (Minority Rights Group, via Refworld). A national dialogue conference followed, meant to rewrite the state, possibly as a federation.

The Houthis in Sanaa and the Saudi coalition (2014-2022). On 21 September 2014 the Houthis, allied with none other than Saleh, entered Sanaa. On 26 March 2015 a coalition led by Saudi Arabia intervened for Hadi; in April Security Council resolution 2216 demanded that the Houthis withdraw and imposed an arms embargo on them (our Glossary; our analysis). In December 2017 the Houthis killed Saleh, who was switching sides. By the end of 2021 the war had caused, according to the UN Development Programme, 377,000 deaths, 60% of them from hunger and disease (our analysis).

The truce and the Presidential Council (2022). In April 2022 the UN brokered a truce. On 7 April Hadi handed his powers to an eight-member Presidential Leadership Council led by Rashad al-Alimi, formed in Riyadh, which brings together the various anti-Houthi forces, Southern separatists included (Sana'a Center). The truce expired in October but has largely held.

The Red Sea (2023-2025). From November 2023 the Houthis attacked ships in the Red Sea over the Gaza war; in 2025 came US and Israeli strikes (our analysis).

The South splits (December 2025 – January 2026). In December 2025 the Southern Transitional Council, the separatist movement backed by the Emirates, occupied Hadramawt and al-Mahra, on the Saudi border. Saudi Arabia responded with air strikes and with forces loyal to it, which retook the two provinces and Aden. Separatist leader Aidarous al-Zubaidi fled to the Emirates; on 9 January a Council delegation announced its dissolution from Riyadh, which its supporters call extorted under pressure (AP, via WTOP; Dawn).

The war returns in full (2026). After the war between the United States, Israel and Iran that began in February 2026, in July the Houthis declared a naval blockade against Saudi Arabia and the two sides struck each other's airports. In September the Houthis took Mokha and the coast on the Bab el-Mandeb; in October they closed off Taiz and the government launched an offensive to retake the whole country (our analysis).

WHO GOVERNS, AND HOW

On paper Yemen is a republic with an elected president and a parliament. In practice there has been no parliamentary vote since 2003 and no presidential vote since 2012, when Hadi was the only candidate (Abaad Studies; Al Jazeera, 2012). Today there are two authorities that each claim to be the state:

- **The recognised government**, led by the Presidential Council based in Aden. It is recognised by the UN and depends on Saudi Arabia for money and protection; after January 2026 the members close to the Emirates were replaced by pro-Saudi figures (TRT World).
- **The Houthi authorities** in Sanaa, who govern the north-west in practice. At the top is Abdul-Malik al-Houthi, who claims a religious right to lead the community reserved for his lineage (our Glossary).

Freedom House, in its 2026 report, rates Yemen "not free", with 10 points out of 100: 1 out of 40 for political rights and 9 out of 60 for civil liberties; elections are years overdue and many institutions no longer function (Freedom House). What separates an autocracy from a democracy is explained in our entry on Autocracy.

WHO'S WHO

Who	Led by	Position
Houthis (Ansar Allah)	Abdul-Malik al-Houthi	Have held Sanaa and the north-west since 2014; since September 2026 also the coast on the Bab el-Mandeb. Allies of Iran (Glossary)
Presidential Council	Rashad al-Alimi	Recognised government, in Aden. Since 4 October 2026 leading the offensive to retake the whole country (our analysis)
National Resistance	Tareq Saleh, nephew of the former president	West-coast forces, on the Presidential Council (Sana'a Center)
Marib forces	Sultan al-Arada, governor	Defend the oil and gas province; on the Presidential Council (same source)
Giants Brigades and National Shield	—	Southern forces and pro-Saudi forces fighting alongside the government; the National Shield retook Hadramawt from the separatists in January 2026 (AP, via WTOP)
Southern separatists	Aidarous al-Zubaidi, in the Emirates	Their Council was dissolved in January 2026, but supporters reject the dissolution and still demonstrate for independence (Dawn)
Islah	—	The Sunni Islamist party, close to the Muslim Brotherhood; present on the Presidential Council (Arab Center Washington)
Al-Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula (AQAP)	—	Jihadist group present mainly in the south-east; also threatens non-Sunni Muslims (US State Department, 2023, via ecoi.net)

WHERE THE CONFLICT COMES FROM

We use the four levels from our piece "Are the world's wars 'Muslim'?".

The ground: two countries badly stitched together. North and South had different histories, states and even opposing ideologies until 1990. Unity came out of necessity and was imposed by force in 1994. In the north, the end of the imamate in 1962 took power away from the families descended from the Prophet, and Salafism from Saudi Arabia spread into Zaydi lands: two wounds on which the Houthis built their movement (our Glossary).

The spark: the vacuum after Saleh. In 2011 Saleh's system collapsed, but no new system took its place. The Houthis exploited a weak transition and, paradoxically, their alliance with Saleh himself to take the capital in 2014.

The flag: religion and independence. The Houthis speak the language of resistance against America, Israel and Saudi Arabia, and of Zaydi rights; the South speaks the language of independence. But the war is also fought among Sunnis, as in the South in January 2026, and religion alone does not explain who sides with whom.

The outside multiplier. Saudi Arabia does not want an ally of Iran on its border; for Iran the Houthis are the most distant and most autonomous ally in its network; the Emirates backed the Southern separatists and the ports for years; the United States and Israel strike the Houthis when the Houthis strike ships or Israel. Since 2026, with Hormuz almost closed, whoever controls the Bab el-Mandeb controls part of the world's oil.

WHO GAINS

We document stated or verifiable interests, not motives. If an actor denies something, we say so.

The Houthis. The war has turned them from a rebel group in one province into the de facto government of millions of people, with regional weight. They demand public salaries, an end to the blockade, the withdrawal of foreign forces and oil revenue (our Glossary).

Saudi Arabia. It wants a friendly government in Sanaa and secure borders, and now also safe routes for its oil in the Red Sea. It pays part of the salaries and expenses of the Aden government: 346.6 million dollars in February 2026 alone; in all, Riyadh says, more than 12.6 billion dollars between 2012 and 2026 (Arab News; Gulf Business, on Saudi sources).

The Emirates. They backed the Southern separatists and the west-coast forces; after January 2026 they were pushed out of the country (TRT World).

Iran. Through the Houthis it holds leverage over the Red Sea and Saudi Arabia. UN experts have reported arms shipments from entities in Iran; Tehran denies it (our Glossary). How far the Houthis really depend on Iran, and where they decide on their own, is explained in our analysis: they depend on it for their most advanced weapons, not for the choices that touch their survival.

Arms sellers. For years the United States and other allies authorised arms sales to coalition members; Amnesty International called for them to stop because of strikes on civilians (Amnesty International, via Dawn).

WHO INTERVENES FROM OUTSIDE

- **Saudi Arabia.** Has led the coalition since 2015; aircraft, money for salaries, allied forces on the ground.
- **United Arab Emirates.** Coalition member; backed the Southern separatists until January 2026.
- **Iran.** Ally of the Houthis; weapons and components according to the UN.
- **United States.** Strikes against the Houthis in 2024 and 2025; in 2026 it is calling on Iran to stop supporting them (Al Jazeera).
- **Israel.** Strikes on Sanaa and Hodeidah in response to Houthi missiles; in a single day of strikes on Sanaa, according to the Houthi health ministry, 46 people were killed, journalists among them (AP, via Arab News).
- **Oman.** Mediator: in July 2026 it let the Iranian flight turned away from Sanaa land in Hodeidah (our analysis).
- **UN.** A special envoy, Hans Grundberg since 2021; a sanctions regime with its panel of experts (resolution 2140 of 2014) and the arms embargo on the Houthis (resolution 2216 of 2015) (UN, resolution 2140).

The human cost. The UN Development Programme estimated 377,000 deaths by the end of 2021, including hunger and disease. ACLED counts more than 160,000 deaths directly caused by the war since 2015 (ACLED, via dpa). In 2026 the UN estimated 22.3 million people in need of aid, including 5.2 million internally displaced (our analysis).

Documented violence. Some examples, attributed to different parties:

- **Saudi coalition, 2015-2019**: about two thirds of the civilians killed in direct attacks on civilians, according to ACLED, died in coalition air strikes (ACLED, June 2019). On 9 August 2018 a strike hit a school bus in the Dahyan market, in Saada province: according to the UN at least 21 children died; the Secretary-General called for an independent and prompt investigation (UN, UNifeed).
- **Houthis, Taiz, since 2015**: the siege of the city, which Human Rights Watch considers a possible war crime of starvation as a method of warfare (HRW); recruitment of child soldiers (our analysis).
- **United States, April 2025**: a strike on a migrant detention centre in Saada killed at least 68 people; Amnesty called for an investigation into a possible war crime (via News.az).
- **Houthis, October 2026**: missiles on a training camp in Shabwa, 73 recruits killed (AP).

INTERNATIONAL LAW

The treaties. Yemen:

- is party to the Geneva Conventions (the North since 1970, the South since 1977) and to both Additional Protocols since 1990: so the second Protocol, on civil wars, also applies, which prohibits starving civilians as a method of combat (ICRC, International Review of the Red Cross; Cambridge);
- signed the Rome Statute in 2000 but **never** ratified it; nor have Saudi Arabia, the Emirates and Iran. The International Criminal Court could act only on a referral from the Security Council (PGA; ReliefWeb).

The Saudi intervention. The coalition says it intervened at the invitation of the legitimate government; with resolution 2216 the Security Council recognised that government and demanded the Houthis withdraw. The invitation can make the intervention lawful, but it does not make individual strikes lawful: each remains subject to humanitarian law. We discuss this in the entry Use of force and self-defence.

An armed group is bound. The Houthis are not a state, but humanitarian law binds them like any party to a civil war: attacking civilians or civilian airports, starving a city and recruiting children are violations for them too.

The missing justice. The UN group of experts that from 2017 investigated crimes by all parties was shut down in 2021 by a vote of the Human Rights Council (International Commission of Jurists). Since then no international body has been investigating. 72 UN staff remain detained by the Houthis (Grundberg, DPPA).

TIMELINE

Year	Event
1st millennium BC	The kingdom of Saba, with its capital at Marib
897	Al-Hadi ila al-Haqq founds the Zaydi imamate in Saada
1839	The British occupy Aden
1904	Boundary line between the Ottoman north and the British south
1918	The north independent under Imam Yahya
1962	Revolution and Yemen Arab Republic (26 September); civil war with Egypt and Saudi Arabia
1967	Independence of the South (30 November)
1969	The Marxists take power in the South
1970	Reconciliation in the north
1972, 1979	Two short border wars between North and South
1990	Unification (22 May)
1994	Civil war; Saleh takes Aden (7 July)
2004-2010	Six wars between the government and the Houthis in Saada
2011	Uprising; Saleh signs the Gulf deal (23 November)
2014	The Houthis enter Sanaa (21 September)
2015	Saudi coalition intervenes (26 March); resolution 2216
2017	The Houthis kill Saleh (December)
2021	UN group of experts shut down; 377,000 deaths estimated
2022	Truce (April); Presidential Council created (7 April)
2023	Houthi attacks in the Red Sea begin; Saba listed as heritage in danger
2025	US and Israeli strikes; separatists occupy Hadramawt and al-Mahra (December)

Year	Event
2026	Contested dissolution of the separatists (January); Houthi blockade and airport war (July-October); fall of Mokha (10 September); siege of Taiz and government offensive (October)

CHANGE LOG

- 5 November 2026: first version.

Sources: Freedom House · GlobalSecurity, on census data · US State Department, 2023, via ecoi.net · Minority Rights Group · Sana'a Center · Minority Rights Group · US State Department, 2019, via ecoi.net · Grundberg to the Security Council, DPPA · AP, via Korea Times · UNESCO · Arab News · Encyclopedia.com · US Marine Corps, country profile · Carnegie · Encyclopedia.com · MIT, CASCON project · Orient XXI · PBS · UCDP · WorldAtlas · Minority Rights Group, via Refworld · Sana'a Center · AP, via WTOP · Dawn · Abaad Studies · Al Jazeera, 2012 · TRT World · Arab Center Washington · US State Department, 2023, via ecoi.net · Arab News · Gulf Business, on Saudi sources · Amnesty International, via Dawn · Al Jazeera · AP, via Arab News · UN, resolution 2140 · ACLED, via dpa · ACLED, June 2019 · UN, UNifeed · HRW · via News.az · ICRC, International Review of the Red Cross · Cambridge · PGA · ReliefWeb · International Commission of Jurists

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